

Discussion of Alexiadou et al.

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Summary and contribution

Theoretical argument: Mainstream parties are increasingly reluctant to raise energy taxes due to fear of electoral backlash. Vulnerability varies across the political spectrum and is shaped by the distributional effects of energy taxes and the pressure exerted by the radical right.

Empirical contribution:

- Internal: Mapping divisions within party electorates using ESS survey data
- External: Radical right positions on energy taxes using manifesto analysis
- Government behaviour: Interaction of radical right/green vote and PM partisanship with Eurostat & OECD tax data

Three comments: Strengthen theoretical justification, devote more attention to causal identification, and reflect more on alternative explanations (carbon taxes, ETS, etc.)

Comment #1: The unique incentives of the radical right

The central claim is compelling: Radical-right parties (RRP) are in a unique position to politicise energy taxes because of their distinct electoral incentives. But why?

- This is most convincing when linked to [distributional politics](#) and [niche party](#) logic (Abou-Chadi and Orlowski, [2016](#); Meguid, [2005](#), [2008](#)).
 - Energy taxes are often regressive (esp. electricity & heating fuels)
 - Rural voters — often a core radical right constituency — face higher effective burdens → chimes well with empirical evidence on the horizontal distributional effects of climate policy instruments being greater than their vertical ones (Missbach and Steckel, [2024](#))
- RRP parties oppose energy taxes to mobilise their base and, potentially, win over economically vulnerable voters by politicising an issue with strong cultural connotations (bundling logic).

I'd suggest developing this link in more detail.

Comment #2: Identifying the effects of energy taxes is tricky

The empirical analysis faces a number of [non-trivial identification challenges](#):

- Do energy tax revenues change because of changes in actual tax rates or in consumption patterns?
- Are we conflating shifts from excise to carbon pricing or ETS rebates?
- Is the observed change politically motivated – or driven by exogenous shocks (e.g. EU obligations, economic crises)?

I think this could be handled with greater clarity through:

- Including robustness checks using polling data (e.g. Kayser, Orlowski, and Rehmert, [2023](#); Kayser and Rehmert, [2021](#))
- Exploiting granularity of tax/revenue data if available (monthly/quarterly data)
- Accounting for substitution between tax instruments: carbon tax vs. excise

Comment #3: Ruling out alternative channels

Beyond domestic party politics, governments may change energy taxation due to:

- Revenue needs (especially because demand tends to be fairly inelastic, which is especially important during recessions)
- EU or international obligations (ETS, climate targets)
- Substitution effects: Energy tax reductions offset by carbon tax hikes

You partially address this — but it could be strengthened by:

- Control for EU ETS pass-through and revenue earmarking using data from World Bank/IMF/[Resources for the Future](#)
- Clarify when “energy taxes” are just replaced by carbon pricing instruments

Energy taxes vs. carbon pricing

Feature	Energy Tax	Carbon Tax
Tax base	Litre, kWh, tonne of fuel	Tonne of CO ₂ (or equivalent)
Scope	Broad (all fuels, end-uses)	Fossil fuels, industry emissions
Calculation	Fixed (€ per unit)	Variable (€ / ton CO ₂)
Carbon precision	Low–moderate	High
Admin complexity	Simple	Moderate
Revenue earmarking	Rare (general budget)	Common (rebates, green funds)
Flexibility	Low	High
Common exemptions	Broad (e.g. transport)	Targeted (e.g. large emitters)

Final thoughts

- A very promising and timely paper — helps explain puzzling trends in energy taxation in advanced democracies
- Strongest when theorising the distinct incentives of the radical right and empirically connecting them to tax decisions
- Some measurement and identification challenges remain, but these are not insurmountable

References I

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